

Information days

ERC Grants: what to expect in 2026 calls

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9.30 - 11.30 CEST

Online

ERCEA

English



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The ERC has introduced some novelties in the **2026 Work Programme**. This info session is designed to help applicants understand how these changes will apply to the submission of applications and evaluation of proposals, ensuring they are well-prepared for the upcoming calls for the Starting, Consolidator and Advanced Grants.

Participants will receive practical guidance on the application process with a focus on:

- the new proposal structure
- the updated rules for the extension of the eligibility period
- the additional relocation funding
- the new resubmission restrictions

While the session is open to researchers based in EU Member States and Horizon Europe Associated Countries, the ERC encourages those in Widening countries to attend, in line with the efforts to increase success rates in countries hosting few ERC grantees.

Note on budget justification

Following the webinar, we have received many questions on where to include the justification for the requested budget in the proposal. In view of this, we would like to clarify and reiterate the information provided in the [Information for Applicants](#) and in the Part B2 template of the submission form on the proposal budget and where to include your justification for the requested budget in your proposal. This states:

"The justification for the requested budget and resources should be explained under the 'Resources' Section in the online submission form (Part A, Section 3 - Budget). Part II of the Scientific Proposal cannot deviate from the Resources section, but may include additional justification where necessary when describing the methodology, work plan, etc."

The budget table and the description of resources (Part A, Section 3 - Budget) will be made available to the experts evaluating the proposal at Step 2 together with Parts B1 and B2, i.e. Parts I and II of the scientific proposal.

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Webinar: ERC Grants: what to expect in 2026 calls

This info session is designed to help applicants to ERC calls understand how changes in the ERC Work Programme 2026 apply to the submission of applications and evaluation of proposals. Hosted by Martin Penny, Head of the Communication Unit at ERCEA, the session will focus on the 2026 calls for the Starting, Consolidator and Advanced Grants.

Duration

Find below the responses to questions raised during the webinar, grouped by topic.

Scientific Proposal

For Starting, Consolidator, Advanced and Synergy Grants, excellence is the sole criterion of evaluation.

The panels will primarily evaluate:

- the ground-breaking nature and ambition of the research project.

At the same time, the panels will evaluate:

- the intellectual capacity and creativity of the Principal Investigator(s), with a focus on the extent to which the Principal Investigator(s) has the required scientific expertise and capacity to successfully execute the project.

Scientific Proposal Structure (2026)

From 2026, the scientific proposal is structured into:

- Part I (max. 5 pages)**
- Part I should make a compelling case why the proposal is an original, creative idea about an important question in the research field(s) and how the project will advance knowledge. It should lay out the current state of knowledge, the major open question(s) and objectives of the project, as well as the overall approach or research strategy to reach the project goals.

In Step 1: Panel members acting as generalists see only Part I of the Scientific proposal (prepare it accordingly). Part I therefore forms the basis for the Panel's decision whether to evaluate the proposal in the next step. All essential information must be covered in this section.

Part II (max. 7 pages for StG/CoG/AdG)

This should be a detailed explanation of the project implementation (feasibility), including research methodology, work plan, risk assessment, and mitigating measures.

The two parts of the proposal should be complementary and not redundant. Part II should not duplicate Part I and will be evaluated only at Step 2. In Part II, you may refer to the objectives outlined in Part I to ensure space efficiency.

At Step 2, reviewers -including both panel members and external referees- will have access to the complete scientific proposal, i.e. both Part I and Part II and the budget section (justification for the requested budget and resources - section C_Resources). Panels have to ensure that the requested resources are reasonable and well justified.

References should be included in both Part I and Part II of the scientific proposal. As in any academic work, they are important for supporting the proposal’s content.

Preliminary results may be included in Part I or II depending if they are important to support the proposed project. However, they are not mandatory, and a proposal will not be rejected solely based on the absence of preliminary results. This is up to the Principal Investigator to decide what they want to include in their proposal.

All figures and information that you want the panel to evaluate must be included in the main body of the proposal, either in Part I or Part II. Panel members will not have access to any annexes or additional material, and they will not evaluate content that exceeds the page limits. References and the Funding ID section are not counted towards these page limits.

The templates of Part B1 and Part B2 that are provided in the submission system (zip-file) should be used. With the change of the page limits, it is even more important that you use your space wisely, making sure all essential information is included in the research proposal.

An ERC application is composed of:

- the administrative form (Part A) including the detailed budget table, description of resources (Section 3 – Budget) and time commitment (Section 5 – Other questions);
- completed Part B1 template (composed of Part I of the Scientific Proposal, Curriculum Vitae and Track Record);
- completed Part B2 template (composed of Part II of the Scientific Proposal and funding ID table);
- mandatory documentation (PhD certificate, Host institution support letter, and, if relevant, any documentation needed to support a request for eligibility extension);
- if applicable, additional supporting documentation related to ethics and security issues.

Budget and Resources

Requested resources must be detailed in:

- **Part A (Section C - Resources)**

Please note that the justification for the requested budget and resources should be explained under the “Resources” Section in the online submission form (Part A, Section 3 - Budget). Part II of the Scientific Proposal cannot deviate from the Resources section but can include additional justification where necessary when describing the methodology, workplan etc.

The indirect costs are automatically calculated based on the costs requested. Applicants do not need to justify indirect costs in the budget justification (nor in part II of the scientific proposal); only direct costs require explanation.

The budget table and the description of resources (Part A, Section 3 - Budget) will be made available to the experts evaluating the proposal at Step 2 together with Parts B1 and B2, i.e. Parts I and II of the scientific proposal. As the budget forms part of the evaluation, it will be assessed accordingly.

Use of AI and External Assistance

Applicants may use AI tools or editing support (e.g., for language), but full authorship responsibility lies with the applicant, who must adhere to scientific integrity standards.

Eligibility

1.Host Institution (HI)

- The HI must support the proposal via a binding Host Institution Support Letter, confirming the PI's independence if selected.
- The PI does not need to be employed by the HI at application stage but must be engaged for the duration of the grant.
- Eligible HIs: Any type of legal entity, public or private, including a university, a research organisation, or an undertaking can host a Principal Investigator and their team. To participate in ERC frontier research actions the Host Institution must be established either in an EU Member State or an Associated Country as a legal entity created under national law, or it may be an international European research organisation (such as the European Organization for Nuclear Research (CERN), and the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL), etc.), or any other entity created under EU law.

2. Project Participation

- For StG, CoG, and AdG, the HI is usually the sole participating legal entity.
- Where they bring scientific added value to the project, additional team members may be hosted by additional legal entities which may be established anywhere, including outside the European Union or Associated Countries, or international organizations. This should be justified in the proposal and the final decision on accepting the budget breakdown is always the responsibility of the review panel.
- Other legal entities established outside the EU or an Associated Country may be funded if their role is essential and provided that they are not under EU sanctions.

3. Submission and Resubmission Restrictions

- Only one application to a main ERC grant (StG, CoG, AdG, SyG) is allowed per call year (under the same Workprogramme). If multiple applications are submitted, only the first eligible proposal will be evaluated.
- For 2026 calls, applicants may apply to any ERC call for which they meet the eligibility criteria, **regardless of whether they have previously held an ERC grant or not**. For example, a Consolidator Grant (CoG) applicant will not necessarily have been a Starting Grant (StG) grantee, and an Advanced Grant (AdG) applicant will not necessarily have been a StG and/or CoG grantee.
- A researcher participating as a Principal Investigator in one of the ERC main frontier research grants may not submit another proposal for an ERC main frontier research grant, unless the existing project ends in less than two years following the call deadline. See ERC WP 2026 (p. 22) for more information.
- Resubmission rules apply based on previous evaluation outcomes. For example:
 - **Step 1 B and C (2025 main calls)** → ineligible for 2026 calls.
 - **Step 2 B (2025 main calls)** → eligible for 2026 calls.
- Inadmissible, ineligible, or withdrawn proposals do not count toward resubmission restrictions.
- For a detailed explanation of the resubmission rules, please see Section 1.4.3 of the ERC WP 2026 and Table 6 included therein.

4. Medical Degrees

- A medical degree alone is not considered equivalent to a PhD.
- Applicants must provide:
 - The Medical degree certificate.
 - Either a PhD certificate or proof of an appointment that requires doctoral equivalency (e.g. postdoc).
 - Research experience documentation (e.g. publications).
- Eligibility reference date = either medical degree + 2 years or PhD defence date, whichever is the earliest degree that makes the applicant eligible.

Extensions to Eligibility Window

Applicants can request extensions if properly documented. Unless otherwise specified, extensions to the eligibility period can only be granted for circumstances or events that have occurred or were present in the period following the Principal Investigator’s PhD Defence Date up until the deadline of the respective call for proposals. Valid extension reasons are:

- **Maternity leave:** 18 months per child born before or after the Principal Investigator’s PhD defence date (or actual documented time if longer).
- **Paternity/parental leave:** actual time taken, full or part-time, including adoption taken for each child born before or after the Principal Investigator’s PhD Defence Date.
- **Long-term illness:** leave taken/ reduced working capacity due to an illness lasting over 90 days, affecting the PI or a close family member.
- **Other reasons:** military service, clinical training (max 4 years), reduced amount of working time (including leave taken) due to PI’s disability, inability to work for a minimum of 90 days due to major disaster, inability to work due to asylum-seeking or due to violence (including gender-based violence). See Table 4, Section 1.4.2.2 of the ERC WP 2026 for details.
- COVID-19 disruptions are **not** valid reasons for extensions unless related to one of the circumstances mentioned in the Work Programme and properly documented (e.g. long-term illness or parental leave). Any other disruption (including COVID-19 disruption) may be described in the CV (Part B1) to explain particular career paths but not to extend the eligibility window.

Only the circumstances stated in the ERC WP 2026 are considered valid for requesting an extension to the eligibility window. Other circumstances (e.g. unemployment or working outside of research) are not one of the valid reasons for extension foreseen in the ERC WP 2026.

Supporting documents must:

- Be signed by the employer or relevant authority.
- Clearly state dates, duration, reason, and part-time/full-time nature if applicable.
- For illness or disability: include medical documents confirming the long-term nature of the condition as well as from a doctor or from the employer confirming the time taken off work, or the percentage of impact a given condition has had on the applicant’s working time.

All requests are reviewed individually by the Admissibility and Eligibility Review Committee, which may request further documentation after the call deadline.

6. PhD Defence Date

The **reference date to calculate eligibility** is the date of successful defence of the first PhD.
If the PhD certificate does not clearly mention this date, provide:

- Written confirmation from the awarding institution mentioning clearly the date of the PhD defence. Applicants may find in the Information for Applicants (page 61) a template that they can request the awarding institution to fill in.
- In case the defence was not successful, a document clearly confirming that the defence was not successful and the date on which corrections were approved.
- If no defence occurred, a letter confirming this and stating the PhD approval date (not award date).

7. Career Stage and Early Applications

- Success rates are similar across the eligibility window, but we advise to apply early so that applicants have the possibility to reapply. Success rate of reapplicants is higher than of first-time applicants.
- Panels consider the time that has passed since the PhD/ the PI’s career stage when assessing CVs.

8. Transitional Arrangements

Applicants hosted by Host Institutions established in countries negotiating their association to Horizon Europe (e.g. Morocco, Egypt, Switzerland) may be treated as eligible, depending on the status of these negotiations at the moment of their application. Eligibility to apply for an ERC grant does not guarantee that these applicants will be able to sign the ERC

grant, if selected for funding. See the [Funding & Tenders portal](#) [↗](#) for updates.

9. Time and Place Commitment

Applicants must meet the minimum time commitments required for their grant (e.g. for CoG 40% time on the grant and 50% time spent in the EU/Associated Country). If the proposal is transferred to a different Host institution, arrangements should be discussed in advance.

10. Career Paths

- Any researcher meeting the eligibility criteria may apply, regardless of current employer or academic path.
- Unconventional career paths should be clearly explained in the CV section.

11. Double Funding

- Projects or parts of projects cannot be funded by more than one source.
- Reusing parts of a previously submitted proposal is not prohibited, but applicants must demonstrate originality and scientific ambition.

PI & CV

Evaluation Panels

Additional Funding

Team members & Collaborators

Budget

Ethics & Security

Research Integrity

PROGRAMME

Moderator

- Martin Penny, Head of Communication Unit, ERCEA

9.30 – 9.35 | Welcome and Introduction

9.35 – 9.45 | Overview of ERC individual grants

- [Martin Penny](#), Head of Communication Unit, ERCEA | [Presentation](#)

9.45 – 10.20 | How to write a successful grant proposal

- [Laura Lobato Bailón](#), Project Adviser, ERCEA | [Presentation](#)

10:20 – 10:40 | Q&A session

10.40 – 11.00 | How to prepare the project budget

- [Georgiana Casiadi](#), Financial Adviser, ERCEA | [Presentation](#)

11.00 – 11.10 | How to deal with ethics requirements

- [Alejandro Aparisi Rey](#), Project Adviser - Ethics, ERCEA | [Presentation](#)

11.10 – 11.25 | Q&A session

11.25 – 11.30 | Closing remarks

Speaker’s bios



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